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ON THE NATURE OF THE THEOLOGICAL METHOD: SOME REFLECTIONS ON THE METHODOLOGICAL PRINCIPLES OF TILlich's THEOLOGY

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I

THE term "theology" occurs for the first time in Plato's critique of Homeric religion, and ever since Plato's critique theology signals a crisis in religion. The hour of theology is come when a mythical configuration breaks down and its symbols that are congealed in a canon come into conflict with a new stage of man's consciousness. When the symbols coined to express man's encounter with the divine at a unique moment of history no longer coincide with his experience, theology tries to interpret the original symbols in order to integrate them within the context of the new situation: what was present in the myth is then only "re-presented" in the theological interpretation.

Theological reflection transforms both the original symbols of the canon and man's consciousness by establishing an equilibrium between them. No human situation is given in absolute nakedness.

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Only through the symbols of language, through the logos, can man orient himself in his surroundings. The symbols demarcate his horizon and govern, as long as they are meaningful, his thought and action. Theology thus recasts man's horizon by interpreting his situation in terms of the canonic symbols, and acts at once as a conserving and as a catalytic force. As apologetics it tries to preserve the original symbols, but, by transferring the symbols of the canon to a changed situation, theology functions catalytically in the birth of a new symbolism. Therefore the task of theology may be described as a dialectic of "perseverance in changing." The equilibrium between symbol and situation is rarely achieved and never more than temporarily. The symbols have their life-cycle in the course of theological interpretation and die when theology can no longer translate them into the temporal situation.

Almost from the very beginning of its history the Christian community sought the services of theology, so that the Christian canonic scriptures not only present a body of original symbols but already represent different stages of theological interpretation. Therefore some could assume that the Christian religion had a specific affinity to theological interpretation and that theology is the legitimate successor of revelation. I do not think that such an interpretation does justice to the beginnings of theology in the Christian religion. Christianity had to make use of theological interpretation

already in its earliest stages because its symbols of faith expressing the expectations of the first generation conflicted very early with the actual situation of the community. For the Christian community was thrown into history against her expectations and against her will, and the hiatus between the eschatological symbols of faith and man's continuing existence in history is as old as the history of the Christian church.

The function of theology in the Christian church remained the same throughout its history. Theology continually transformed the eschatological symbols to an ever changing historical situation and carried through this transformation with the help of the Platonic and, later, of the Aristotelian philosophy, turning the eschatological symbols into ontological symbols. Without this perpetual act of transformation the Christian community would have degenerated into a "narrow and superstitious" sect and the general culture would have bypassed this community without taking notice of it. But no religion can have the luxury of theology without paying a price for it. Secularization is the price the Christian community had to pay for its development from an adventistic sect to a universal church, and the history of theology is the spiritual account of this price. It would be iconoclastic to deny to a community any right of development, to outlaw all transformation, to declare all commentary as fake, and to argue that only the text is valid. It would be idolatrous, however, to overlook the perennial conflict between text and commentary and to fail to emphasize that the canonic text is "broken" through the prism of interpretation. The history of the development of Christian theology is a tragic history because there is no "solution" to the conflict between eschatological sym-

bols and the brute fact of a continuing history. One may admire the achievement of theology but at the same time be aware of the price involved in such an achievement.

But a situation can arise which makes it impossible for theology to fulfil its task of interpretation. Christian theology, like all theology bound to a canonic text, uses the method of allegorical interpretation and does so by necessity. The entire history of theological interpretation is a running commentary to the original text. But what if the very method of allegorical interpretation becomes suspect? Is a theological exegesis of a Holy Writ possible together with a historical analysis of the text? Does not historical interpretation qua method imply a criticism of all theological exegesis? Whereas theological exegesis must "transfer"—this is the original meaning of translation—the original symbols by the method of allegorical interpretation into a given situation, the historical analysis interprets the text, the canonic symbols, in their original historical context.

In the nineteenth century the historical criticism of religion reached its height. The nineteenth century was a period of Old and New Testament criticism, it was the century of *Leben-Jesu-Forschung*, it was the century of the history of dogma. It remained obscure, however, to most historians, why they were driven into this tempest of historical inquiry. Ferdinand Christian Baur wrote his classical history of dogma under the Hegelian assumption that this development had come to an end. Even if Harnack did not subscribe to the speculative assumptions of the Tübingen school, he nevertheless arrived at the same conclusion when he, the historian of Christian theology, pressed the "essence" of Christianity into a "religion of

Jesus," discarding all Christological doctrines as dead weight. It was Nietzsche who discovered (what Hegel and his pupils may have known but did not admit) the driving force behind the passion of historical research: the death of the Christian God. Historical research, Nietzsche observed, works only as a post mortem, dissecting the body for the sake of anatomical study and writing an obituary.

After the first World War, however, a new generation of Christian theologians arose that experienced the catastrophe of war in terms of eschatological symbols. The apocalyptic symbols of the New Testament, symbols that had been the stumbling block for theology throughout the entire history of the Christian church, suddenly spoke with an immediacy and self-evidence that needed no further interpretation. No allegorical translation seemed necessary, for only apocalyptic symbols could express the actual situation. With the first World War a "world" broke into pieces. Man experienced himself as estranged in his social and cosmic setting and did not feel at home in a world he had so painstakingly cultivated to make his own. When the façades of culture and civilization crumbled under the impact of the first World War man was confronted with the realities of life: hunger, destitution, and death. I do not minimize the significance of dialectical theology when I suggest that the situation of the twenties was catalytic for its development, for a theology is significant only when it responds to a concrete situation.

Karl Barth's commentary on Paul's Epistle to the Romans marks the birth of dialectical theology after the verdict of death had been announced by Nietzsche in the nineteenth century. His commentary is a powerful and penetrating analy-

sis of man's situation and gave voice to man's self-estrangement long before philosophy had taken notice of it. The divine and the human were put in antithesis and any attempt to approach the divine was unmasked as human *hybris* and illusion. Karl Barth's critique of religion did not fall short of the criticism by Feuerbach, Marx, and Nietzsche. In fact his theological criticism of religion aimed to outdo all secular criticism—in order to bring all human thought and action under divine judgment and to open it to the paradox of redemption. God was experienced in his strange otherness to the world and the last trace of the divine was erased from the human realm so that for all practical purposes the earth was left under the rule of the secular. This analysis of man and his cosmos strangely coincided in its diagnosis with the atheistic interpretation of man's actual situation.

As an analysis of man's situation, Barth's commentary is highly significant; but as a commentary on Paul's Epistle to the Romans, it remains a dubious enterprise, combining revolutionary insight into the meaning of the original symbols with an anachronistic exegesis. The program of a pneumatic exegesis only veiled the confusion concerning the historical method. By stressing the antithesis between the divine and the human to the point of paradox, dialectical theology spelled out concretely man's self-estrangement, but under the cloak of paradox it smuggled in some very unparadoxical stereotypes of Protestant orthodoxy. And the later development of dialectical theology into a theological positivism only confirmed the fears of a critic like Harnack that this revival in theology would but contribute a Quixote episode to the history of theology, because neither the presuppositions of a pneumatic exegesis nor the conditions for

an orthodox supernaturalism could be revived at will. When the first revolutionary impetus of dialectical theology came to a halt and the conservative restoration of dogmatics began (a shift more significant as a general sign of our time than dialectical theology would like to admit), the attempt to develop theology out of man's actual situation had proven itself abortive.

II

It is in such a period of orthodox restoration that Paul Tillich has published the first volume of his *Systematic Theology*. This work presents a challenge to the verdict that the creative development of theology has come to an end. Tillich seriously considers the charge that the history of theology represents a progressive amnesia, suppressing the eschatological meaning of the canonic symbols. He tries to escape the verdict of historical criticism by a solution that is as bold as it is simple: by interpreting ontology in terms of eschatology he charges ontology with eschatological dynamics. Thus he thinks it is possible to interpret eschatological symbols in ontological terms without sacrificing their original meaning. In short, he eschatologizes ontology and ontologizes eschatology in the light of man's present situation.

The starting point of his theology is the experience of despair that marks so much of contemporary art and literature, that comes to voice in existential philosophy and is analyzed in the psychology of the unconscious. Man is seen in an extreme situation that cannot be treated in the traditional stereotypes: neither the ontological speculations of the early Greek church nor the concern of the Reformation with a merciful God and the forgiveness of sin nor the modernistic problem of personal religious life or of the

Christian community in the general civilization is at stake. His entire system rotates around the one eschatological problem: man's self-estrangement in his being and his reconciliation in the "new being." When after the first World War the social antagonism between the bourgeois society and the proletarian class seemed to determine man's situation, Tillich tried in a theology of *kairos* to meet the challenge of Marxism in terms of a Christian socialism. Tillich's theological criticism of the bourgeois society wanted to integrate the Marxist critique of capitalism. The second World War has brought a clear shift in his emphasis from social concerns to psychological problems: not the class struggle determines man's self-estrangement, but man's despair transcends the social division of classes. Tillich tries to meet the challenge of existential philosophy and psychiatry, and his theological analysis of man's despair aims to reveal the unuttered theological a priori of their inquiry. Tillich's theology is apologetic, based on a method of correlation. This method determines the scaffolding of the system which in the first volume is built around the main problems of "I. Reason and Revelation (1. Reason and the Quest for Revelation; 2. The Reality of Revelation)" and "II. Being and God (1. Being and the Question of God; 2. The Reality of God)."

The technique of correlation is not entirely new in the field of apologetic theology and was employed by the Lutheran theologian Karl Heim in a masterly way. In his analysis of the categories of the natural sciences and the concepts of epistemology and ontology Karl Heim unearthed the inner contradictions in their basic axioms and used this crisis in the foundations of science and philosophy to drive man's search for knowledge

from intellectual skepticism into an existential despair. Having brought human knowledge to the impasse of despair, Karl Heim turned about to reveal the answer of theology in which all contradictions were resolved and all antagonisms reconciled. Even if the student could not help but admire the author's skill, this technique left him more skeptical toward theology in the end than in the beginning because it gave him the feeling that the method of correlation works like a trick where the theologian, not unlike a magician, pulls the theological answer out of the dark. The analysis of man's situation in no way affected the terms of the theological answer. The crisis of man's knowledge left no scars on theology, and the theological answer did not pass through the mills of the dialectic but appeared superimposed on the analysis.

Tillich's method of correlation is dialectical. His interest in sociology, psychology, and philosophy is not peripheral, but he participates in the cleavages and contradictions, and his analysis of the human situation shapes the theological answer decisively. The theological element of the correlation is forged in his dialectic as much as the anthropological pole. Our interest is not the apologetic technique of correlation but the dialectical principle it involves.

In order to unravel the dialectic of Tillich's method of correlation we would have to discuss his work chapter by chapter. Such a procedure would go beyond the limits of an essay and would, moreover, remain fragmentary since the second volume of his *Systematic Theology* has not yet been published. Therefore I have chosen to treat two methodological points. First, I will consider the necessary presuppositions of a theological system written from an apologetic point of

view; this problem centers around the question of theology and authority. Next I will consider the method of correlation; this problem centers around the relation between theology and philosophy.

III

The first sentence of Tillich's introduction contains in a nutshell the problem of theology and authority. For theology is defined "as a function of the Christian church" which must serve the needs of the church. Since the dogmatic part constitutes the most significant element in a system of theology, dogmatics is another name for systematic theology and the term "dogmatics" is justified because theology "exercises a function of the church within the church and for the church" (p. 32).¹ The church rests on a foundation whose formulation is given in the creeds, and the function of the creeds "as a protection against destructive heresies" makes their acceptance necessary for the church. With the complete union of church and state after Constantine, the doctrinal decisions of the church became also the civil laws of the state, so that the heretic was considered a criminal who endangered the foundations of the Christian society. The destructive consequences of the union of church and state have discredited the term "dogma" and "dogmatics" and brought the subject of dogmatics into disrepute. But this disrepute is, according to the author, only a historical calamity and does not reduce the significance of formulated *dogmata* for a systematic theology, because the function of systematic theology is a necessary consequence of the nature of the church.

What are the presuppositions of such a claim? The basis of theology as a function of the church rests, according to Tillich,

on the doctrine of the logos that became flesh, of the principle of divine self-revelation that has become manifest in Jesus as the Christ, who is the "head" of the "body" of the church. But the idea of a theology as a function of the church is meaningful only if this doctrine is exposed in a direct way. For there must be a nonsymbolic point of reference beyond all dialectics, the rock on which theology as a function of the church may rest. The dialectical method, however, must always turn the logos that became flesh into a symbol. Surely Tillich is right to insist that a symbol is much more than merely a technical sign. But a symbol remains a "*chiffre*." Can, however, a *chiffre* carry the burden of a theology as a function of the church?

The tension between the theology of logos and the doctrine of the church not only marks Tillich's theology but comes to the fore at the most critical juncture of the history of the Church. Since the Alexandrian school of theology has turned the logos of the particular event into a symbol of the "pneumatic logos," the idea of theology as a function of the church has become problematic. A theology of the logos must face three major turning points in the history of the church: the theology of Origen, the prophecy of Joachim of Fiore, and the philosophy of Hegel. The church could not but anathematize Origen after long controversies because his theology of the logos tends, even against his will, to overcome the unique event of the logos in the flesh. It is true that neither Origen nor Joachim of Fiore nor even Hegel state that the creeds of the church are fulfilled and superseded. Nevertheless, this statement is implicit in the dialectical principle. The dialectical method is not a coach that can be stopped at will. The arguments around Origen and his pupils

in the old church, around Joachim of Fiore and the Franciscan Spirituals in the medieval church, and around Hegel and his pupils in the modern church give abundant testimony to this contention.

A theology that has a function in the church cannot function without the authority of the church, and this authority is derived from the credo that Christ as the logos has a continuous life in the community, the church representing the mystical body of Christ. Theology as a function of the church is meaningful only as a continuation of the incarnation, as the logos that became flesh in the *dogmata*.

If the theological task is understood in this rigorous way (and this is one possible interpretation of Tillich's first sentence), then, it seems to me, theology cannot be treated in a systematic way. Not because it is too difficult to prepare a systematic account of the *dogmata* of the church (every catechism does that) but because the incarnation of Christ cannot be treated as a systematic axiom. I do not wish to say that one cannot for pedagogical purposes present the doctrines of the church in a systematic treatise, but one would fail to understand Tillich's basic assumption if one would suppose that he presents theology in the form of a system for pedagogical reasons. The form of his system is connected with the very nature of his theology and he states explicitly that it has always been impossible for him to think theologically in any other than a systematic way. *Systematic Theology* as a title implies that theology is a system. Perhaps theology as a totality of consistent assertions about the *dogmata* can be systematic, but a theology that is the function of the church is not so much a totality of consistent assertion as an exegesis of the logos that became flesh. Such a theology is possible only as an in-

terpretation of the divine word of revelation. To know does not mean to construct a system but to understand the word of the Scriptures in the light of the authorities of the church. Ecclesiastical theology is based on an *argumentum ex verbo* and not on an *argumentum ex re*.

But Tillich's theology is not an *argumentum ex verbo*. It cannot be accidental that with Tillich "the elaboration of the line of thought has consumed all effort and all space" (p. vii), preventing him from making extensive reference to the Scriptures and the classical theologians. In an ecclesiastical theology reference to the Scriptures and classical authorities is not an embellishing ornament to prove the author's knowledge but belongs to the very core of the argument.

Tillich's theology, however, necessarily takes the form of a system, since the method of commentary by pneumatic exegesis, as it appears in Barth's dogmatics, is rendered anachronistic through the impact of historical criticism. But at the same time Tillich would like to preserve the role of theology as function of the church under conditions that render the very premise of such a role questionable.

If the proposed interpretation of theology seems too rigorous, one would have to consider its possible alternative, and to understand theology and the *dogmata* of the church as the product of creative human imagination. For the historical interpretation of Holy Writ and of the development of dogma in no way permits any conclusion about a continuous act of revelation. The historical interpretation of canonic writings ranges from a conservative reconstruction of minute details in the life of Jesus to a radical denial of any historical existence. Both extremes and the interval between them have to be taken into account by a systematic the-

ology that accepts the results of historical criticism. In fact, the historical interpretation tries to unmask all history as human and only human. A comparison of a historical commentary with any pneumatic exegesis reveals the "unbridged gap" (p. 36) between the two methods. A theology that accepts historical criticism not only "suffers" because of this situation but is actually paralyzed as long as it wants to steer a middle course between historical interpretation and pneumatic exegesis.

It is precisely the "philosophical" element (p. 18) in historical criticism that opposes the assumptions of a pneumatic exegesis. In fact, the philological method was developed in opposition to the allegorical interpretation in order to break the "prejudice" of theology. In charging theology with prejudice, historical criticism aims to emancipate itself from the theological presupposition that truth is *given* to man only by the divine word of revelation. A theology of the church that understands itself in the light of a divine word of revelation would have to unmask the assumption of historical criticism to work without the presuppositions of the given word of revelation as an illusion of the autonomous mind. In order to legitimize pneumatic exegesis, theology would have to carry through a "critique of historical reasoning" and to show that the driving principle of historicism, the "historical consciousness," actually epitomizes human *hybris* and illusion. Leo Strauss, in his study of Spinoza's critique of religion, has developed the genesis of this problem and shown the philosophical implications of historical criticism in such a pertinent way that I do not need to repeat his argument in detail.² But not even theological positivism dared to go so far and left the problem of historical criticism in a confused limbo. Erwin

Reisner, who pointed out that historical criticism was not only a question of philological accuracy but had philosophical implications that shake the foundations of Christian revelation, remained a voice in the desert.³ The church could tolerate the historical interpretation of the canon and the dogma only at the peril of its existence, since such an interpretation reduces the church to one sociological group among others immersed in the conflicts of the world.

Perhaps the time has come when theology must learn to live without the support of canon and classical authorities and stand in the world without authority. Without authority, however, theology can only teach by an indirect method. Theology is indeed in a strange position because it has to prove its purity by immersing itself in all the layers of human existence and cannot claim for itself a special realm. In losing itself in the forms of the world, theology would not betray its destiny. Richard Rothe, the teacher of Ernst Troeltsch, knew something about this destiny of theology. Theology must remain incognito in the realm of the secular and work incognito for the sanctification of the world. Theology should not strive for the vainglory to present a sacred science "separated" from the sciences by special doctrines or dogmas but rather serve in "lowliness of mind" the secular knowledge and life. Would theology miss its point if instead of insisting on a separating circle it would make itself of no special reputation and take upon itself the form of incognito? Theology would in such a fashion become more likely to present the relation between the divine and the human in our time.

IV

Tillich's systematic theology is not only a theology of the church; it is philo-

sophical theology, and therefore he develops his theology in a continuous correlation with philosophy. His purpose is to define within the limits of a philosophic theology the special *topos* of theology and to establish a criterion for distinguishing it from philosophy. While philosophy inquires into the structure of being, theology deals with the meaning of being for us. The subject matter of theology is what concerns us ultimately. Only those propositions are theological which deal with their object insofar as it can become a matter of ultimate concern for us.

But here we must ask, "Is there any criterion for determining what should be of man's ultimate concern? Could not everybody put his ultimate concern as theology?" Only those statements, answers Tillich, are theological which deal with their object insofar as it can become a matter of being or not-being for us. The question, to be or not to be, implies a specific theological point. But even the second criterion remains formal. Man's ultimate concern is fundamentally rooted in the ontological question. Ontology is not a theoretical doctrine but an act of questioning in which man asks about the ground of his being. Only in the chapter following the exposition of the two formal criteria of theology does Tillich discuss a material criterion of theology by defining theology as a methodical interpretation of the contents of the Christian faith. This statement remains obscure, however, in its relation to the two formal criteria and makes sense only if we remember that theology is by definition a function in the church. It is the ecclesiastical element in the texture of Tillich's theology that leads him to limit the theological circle and to demarcate the line between theology and philosophy. But this theological circle has a very wide radius. For the only criterion whereby the circum-

ference of the circle can be drawn is again man's ultimate concern with the Christian message. His ultimate concern can express itself through opposition no less than through submission. Are Feuerbach and Nietzsche, then, within the theological circle?

Tillich's division between philosophy and theology poses a crucial problem for philosophy. If philosophy should deal, as Tillich assumes, only with the structure of being in itself, whereas theology deals with the meaning of being for us, then philosophy *qua* philosophy would have to remain in a detached objectivity and forget about man's concrete condition. But is it at all possible to inquire into the structure of being without first considering its meaning for us? For all ontological inquiry into the structure of being, though it develop the most elaborate system of categories, remains fundamentally empty until it has clarified the meaning of being for us. I do not see any possible split between theology and philosophy in the ontological question. For an inquiry into the structure of being, its categories and concepts, which does not beforehand establish the meaning of being for us is doomed to failure. An ontology that stops short at describing objective structures without recourse to the subjective source of this act remains ungrounded.

The division between the universal logos and the concrete logos cannot be interpreted in terms of Tillich's theological circle. The universal logos must at all times be bound to the concrete, otherwise it becomes a mere phantom of generalities. The union between the universal and the concrete cannot be ontologically "dependent" on an event in the course of history. If ontology is eschatologized and eschatology ontologized, then the drama between "being" and the "new being" must be a perennial act.

The act of reconciliation must either be an eternal event or it must put an end to man's being in history. The original eschatological symbols of the antagonism and reconciliation between the *protos adam* and the *eschatos adam* had an inner coherence that is lacking in a theology that has to reckon with the fact of a Christian history and to turn the eschatological symbols into ontological concepts and make the eschaton break into history at an arbitrary moment within history.

It is probable that such or similar considerations have prevented Martin Heidegger from accepting the ontological interpretation of theology which would seem to be the most natural correlatum to his philosophy of being. In sentences that could be taken as a direct comment on Tillich's theology, Heidegger remarked, "If I were to write a theology, which I am sometimes tempted to do, [then] the term "being" would not be allowed to appear in it. Faith does not need the thought of being, and if it needs it it is no longer faith. This Luther understood. Even in his own church one seems to forget it" (Zurich, November, 1951).⁴ Heidegger remains cryptic as to how he would develop the categories of his theology, but this much is clear: that he separates ontology from theology like Kierkegaard and Barth. I cannot but take Tillich's side in this argument, although I doubt whether the ontological interpretation of theology can be confined within the limits of the theological circle.

Is Tillich's *systematic* theology, however, confined ultimately to the theological circle? It is the paradoxical destiny of logos-theology to end in a theology of immanence. This consequence is implicit in the very principle of dialectic. It cannot be denied that Tillich's theology describes the disruptive cleavages of reason

and man's alienation in general. But is the reconciliation described theologically, as a "supernatural" breakthrough, as a miraculous healing of the conflict in man? If the supernatural pole is dialectically drawn into the orbit of the world and the divine interpreted in the light of the mystery of incarnation, then the divine becomes immersed in the world, becomes an immanent principle. The divine no longer stands over and against man but is in the depth of his own being. The law of God (theonomy) is no longer a divine decree to man but only "autonomous reason united with its own depth" (p. 85). In such a situation it "is as atheistic to affirm the existence of God as it is to deny it" (p. 237), for God is not a being standing over and against man, calling him, commanding him, arguing with him, but "being itself."

It is important, I think, to inquire into the "topology" of the symbols that are basic to the ontological interpretation of theology. According to Tillich, they are all located in a "depth." The "depth" of reason expresses something that is not reason but that precedes reason and is manifest through it. That which transcends reason is not located "beyond" reason, but the arrow of transcendence points "downward" into the depth. The depth of reason is interpreted as "substance" which appears in the rational structure of reality. Substance also marks the "depth," the "below," and points to that which is "underlying" reality (sub-stantia). The ontological metaphors are even more pointed. The depth is called the "ground" which is creative in every rational act, or the "abyss" which "cannot be exhausted" by any act of creation, or the "infinite potentiality of being and meaningful" which "pours" into the rational structures of mind and reality. The depth is

the center of power, and out of the depth all rational structures receive their form (p. 79). All these symbols are metaphorical variations of the unsymbolic term "being itself." The religious symbol for what is called the "ground of being" is God (p. 156).

The point of reference for all these ontological symbols lies in the depth. Since Tillich interprets theology in ontological terms, his basic theological and religious symbols must retain the quality of depth characteristic of Dionysiac theology. Dionysiac theology is an "ecstatic naturalism" that interprets all supernaturalistic symbols in immanent terms. The ecstasy does not lead to a "beyond," in a supernaturalistic sense, but signifies an "intensity" of the immanent. In the last analysis, it is the idea of a Dionysiac theology that secretly impels all philosophical theology, and in the convergence and union of the bacchantic dance and the mystery of the cross, I see the mythical original of the dialectical method. Nietzsche's last utterances point in the same direction. At the end of his *Ecce homo*, Dionysos stands symbolically against the Crucified. In the letters and fragments, however, written in a last clarity of mind before he entered into the night of madness, the veil is lifted from Nietzsche's ultimate concern: Dionysos and the Crucified merge into one symbol. It is the same union of Christ and Dionysos that Hölderlin celebrates in his last hymns. And the theoretical blueprint for the mythical union of Christ and Dionysos is given in the philosophy of Hegel and the late Schelling. The method of dialectic is rooted in Böhme's gnostic theogony of the eternal yea and the eternal nay. Hence, Tillich's ontological interpretation of theology, which is his most original contribution, adds a chapter to the

history of Dionysiac theology in the Christian frame of reference.

It is unavoidable that in the context of a Dionysiac theology some of the biblical attributes and metaphors for the divine, which belong to a paternalistic frame of reference, become "confusing" symbols. It needs all the power of Tillich's interpretation to hold the paternalistic symbols in line with the Dionysiac symbols of his philosophical theology. In the last pages of the volume, for example, Tillich is concerned with the criticism of the personalistic symbols for man's relation to God. The two "central" symbols of biblical faith, Lord and Father, have become a stumbling block for many people. Christian theology has been "unwilling to listen to the often shocking insights into the psychological consequences of the traditional use of these symbols" (p. 288). No doubt this remark touches upon a crucial point, but I would question whether the "traditional use" can be eliminated; that is, I would question whether the symbols can be removed from their original context. No interpretation of a symbol can ultimately uproot the symbol from its natural soil. A symbol explains itself through itself and breaks through all the veils of interpretation. It is important for theology to take the criticism of psychology and sociology seriously, but perhaps it is worth while to consider, even if only for a moment, whether the fact that the paternalistic symbols have become a stumbling block is not in fact a verdict on our spiritual situation. These symbols were in no way disturbing to many generations that shaped their traditional use, and the symbols would never have become so central to the Jewish and the Christian language of faith if their traditional use had conflicted with their meaning. May

not the criticism of paternalistic symbols by psychology be the result of a tacit assumption of a theology of immanence?

Tillich's Dionysiac *theo-logy* challenges the ecstatic Dionysiacs like Ludwig Klages, Keyserling, and other disciples of the pagan cult, who descend into the night and worship earth, race, blood, flesh as sacred powers, abhorring reason as the enemy of the soul. The spirit pulses through the Dionysiac elements in Tillich's theology, which tries to reconcile the powers of the deep that are sacred and the powers of light that are divine. The spirit does not live in enmity with life, but even the abyss of being is illuminated by a logos.

V

Hegel also understood the dialectical method as an explication of the mystery of the incarnation and centered his ontology around Christian symbols. No one can understand the dialectical method unless he refers to Hegel's analysis of "life" and "love" in his earlier theological writings. This analysis is deeply interwoven with an interpretation of the prologue of the Gospel of John. But in the *Phenomenology of the* [human or divine?] *Spirit*, Hegel reveals the secret inherent in the dialectical method of logos-theology. Logos-theology contains, according to Hegel, the method, the way in the deepest sense, leading from the contradictions of alienation to man's self-recognition. The logos that became explicit in theology is the spirit that recognizes itself; it is reason united with its own depth. Hegel also describes the logos as distinct but no longer outside of man and draws the supernatural pole into the circle of dialectic. The dynamics of the dialectical method break through the limits of a theological circle because the

principle of dialectic cannot fulfil itself without sacrificing theology as an objective doctrine. Only in the situation of estrangement can man speak about his ultimate concern in an estranged way, in the way of theology; and, as a doctrine, theology perpetuates the estrangement of man that it set out to overcome. The structure of Hegel's *Phenomenology* testifies to this dynamism of the dialectical method. The *Phenomenology* does not end with a description of the logos-theology but proceeds to a gnostic theory of knowledge, a doctrine that is neither theology nor philosophy in the strict sense but both at the same time. This doctrine has its source in the Alexandrian theology and in the speculations of Joachim of Fiore. Hegel's doctrine is not a philosophy in the sense of a theory that abstracts from man; and it is not a theology in the supernaturalistic sense, for it does not locate the spirit outside of man. In Hegel's logos-theology the supernatural symbols are finally translated into immanent categories.

It is true that Hegel's synthesis crumbled, since he reconciled the contradictions and oppositions of life only in the realm of the idea and relegated nature, matter, and man's material condition to a secondary position. The social and scientific revolution of the nineteenth century burst through the dikes of Hegel's idealistic synthesis. Schelling, in his lectures on the *Philosophy of Mythology and Revelation*, was the first to stress the primacy of being over the "negative" realm of the pure idea—and Tillich started his work forty years ago with an analysis of Schelling's "positive" philosophy. Schelling, who turned the wheel from idealism to a general revolt against Hegel's synthesis, still interpreted being in objective terms, whereas some of

Hegel's pupils (Feuerbach and Kierkegaard) shifted the emphasis from the objective pole of being to the principle of subjectivity.

When Tillich defines the object of theology in terms of man's ultimate concern, he tries, if I understand the structure of his ontological theology, to mediate Schelling's primacy of being with Feuerbach's principle of subjectivity. Feuerbach also argued against Hegel that the pure logos needs to be "incarnated" and "realized" in man's concrete existence, and he also understood the principle of subjectivity in reference to Protestant theology. "In contrast to Catholicism, Protestantism has ceased to be concerned with God per se and is interested only in what he means for man. . . . Protestantism is no longer theology but essentially Christology, i.e. religious anthropology."⁵ Like Tillich, Feuerbach quotes Luther's famous saying, "As you believe him, so you have him," as his key word. Feuerbach would, like Tillich, insist that theistic religion "has made God a heavenly, completely perfect person who resides above the world and mankind. The protest of atheism against such a highest person is correct. There is no evidence for his existence, nor is he a matter of ultimate concern. God is not God without universal participation" (p. 245). Feuerbach, again like Tillich, no longer envisages matter as an antispiritual principle but interprets spirit as immanent in matter as the ecstasy of nature and the intensity of man's existence. Feuerbach's reference to Protestant theology, however, lost its meaning when in the course of years his naturalism became a positive, undialectical principle. Religion then turned out to be only an illusion and the spirit an ideological instrument. Perhaps all materialism had to end

in atheistic revolt in the nineteenth century and sink into a positive materialism, because Protestant theology (against which the revolt was directed) equated the divine with the spiritual, excluding nature and matter from redemption.

Tillich's dialectic tries to break this deadlock. His dialectic does not drive toward a reconciliation in the realm of the idea. It is a dialectic that does not relegate nature and man's material condition to a secondary position; it takes the individual, the ephemeral, as seriously as the idea. But in its methodological structure Tillich's dialectic is, like Hegel's, a dialectic of mediation that drives toward a coincidence of opposites. Tillich's theology, like all philosophical theology from Origen to Hegel, considers its interpretation of the canonic symbols as an advance over the "naïve" belief. Tillich interprets theological reflection as a progress in understanding. Perhaps this is the destiny and the limitation of all theology. For theology must interpret the transition from the myth to the logos as an advance and reflection as an achievement and therefore fails to see that theological reflection presupposes that the original power of the symbol is gone. Theological reflection starts with the resignation that the symbols do not speak through themselves. The ascent to reflection involves a descent from the original relation into an imaginary reconstruction.

Surely, theological interpretation is an achievement, and perhaps it is only by way of dialectic that we can translate the original symbols for the present situation. But perhaps it is the "temporal situation" that *forces* theology to use the dialectical method. That the theologian has to resort to interpretation is only the reverse side of the fact that the symbols have grown mute. It may very well be

that only dialectical terms that border on atheism are appropriate to the present situation. But I would not conclude from this that the dialectical interpretation of the symbols is on a "higher level" than their primitive meaning. For the first generation of Christian believers the coming of the Messiah was a reality and not an ontological problem. Many generations did not stumble over the concreteness of central symbols like Father, Lord, or King of Heaven. And I would not hold it against these generations that they could use these symbols naïvely and did not need to develop an allegorical or dialectical interpretation. Anyone who, after two thousand years of Christian history, thinks that he can ignore the hiatus of time is the victim of an illusion, and Tillich rightly reproves all fundamentalist and orthodox theology. But why make a virtue out of a necessity? The progress in theological interpretation throughout history runs parallel with a gradual withdrawal of divine presence. Theological "re-presentation" and theological interpretation are driven deeper and deeper into the web of dialectics because the divine presence is more and more veiled.

It may seem contradictory to push the dialectical principle beyond the limits that Tillich has set and at the same time to interpret his method of dialectics in the light of the absence of the divine. But perhaps the dialectical method implies precisely such a union of contraries, for it is at once a method of opposition (*dia*-lectic) and a method of reconciliation (*dia*-lectic). The dialectic of mediation (Hegel, Tillich) considers the development of theology only as a path of gradual elucidation and illumination. The dialectic of opposition (Kierkegaard, Barth) tries to bypass history and to

jump over the gap that lies between the original symbols and the present situation. Both uses of the term "dialectic" are legitimate and strangely enough, in the last analysis, their results coincide. "Dialectical theology" opposes the divine to the human to the degree that the divine became the totally "other" to the

world. The theology of mediation involves the divine in the human dialectic to the point that the divine pole of the correlation loses all supernatural point of reference. The two methods seem to contradict each other but in fact equally testify to the eclipse of the divine in our present situation.

NOTES

1. All page references, unless otherwise indicated, refer to Tillich's *Systematic Theology*, Vol. I (Chicago, 1951).

2. Leo Strauss, *Die Religionskritik Spinozas* (Berlin, 1930).

3. Erwin Reisner, *Die Geschichte als Sündenfall und Weg zum Gericht* (München, 1929).

4. Published for private circulation (Zurich, 1952).

5. Ludwig Feuerbach, *Grundsätze der Philosophie der Zukunft*, p. 2.